

collector and servicer spun off from another loan company, Sallie Mae, that is about \$26,000. (Over the course of writing this book, I paid off the two smaller Nelnet ones. Go me!) I learned the exact amount of the loans I had ten years after I took them out. (I take back that “Go me!”) I never looked before that because I assumed the number was so high that it would be unfathomable to me. (It is.) I lived my life as if my loans didn’t exist while my mom paid them off in tiny increments. Many people similarly bury their indebted heads in the loan sand, and a lot of them have it way worse than my sister and I do.

In his stand-up special “Kid Gorgeous,” the comedian John Mulaney has an incredible joke about his own student loans. Mulaney, who is in his mid-thirties, railed against paying \$120,000 (“in 1999 money!”) to major in English and not read any of the books he was assigned to read. He basically paid that much to party, he said. “Let’s face it,” he joked, “if you’ve graduated from college and you’re still giving money to your alma mater, you’re like a john that’s fallen in love with his prostitute.” The entire bit perfectly highlights my own regrets about paying for school (and the absurdity of colleges then asking, after graduation for “MORE MONEY!,” as he screamed during his show).

Adriana Ariza, a 25-year-old graduate student at Claremont University in her third year of a developmental psychology degree, had \$75,000 in federal loans when I interviewed her in 2017. She’s aiming for a PhD and had three years left in her program, which takes seven years total.

As a first-generation college student, Ariza didn’t have any guidance from her parents when it came to student loans. Her father is an immigrant from Mexico. Both her parents drilled into her that she needed to go to college in the land of opportunity. In the end, she estimates she’ll be \$82,000 total in student loan debt, a massive number that takes my breath away. Within psychology, she explained, you can’t get a decent-paying job with just a bachelor’s degree, but furthering your education puts you even more into debt. It’s a financial Ouroboros.

Ariza said she and her friends in similar positions view the numbers as too outrageous to even think about, so they don’t. And if they do, they believe either the debts will be wiped out by a nationwide student loan crisis or Ariza thinks maybe she’ll just die with them. *C’est la vie!* (I like this girl.)